Am sitting atop a lotus pedestal;
On a thousand flowers surrounding me
Are a thousand Sakyamuni Buddhas.
Each flower supports a hundred million worlds;
In each world a Sakyamuni Buddha appears.
All are seated beneath a Bodhi-tree,
All simultaneously attain Buddhahood.
All these innumerable Buddhas
Have Vairocana as their original body.
These countless Sakyamuni Buddhas
All bring followers along -- as numerous as
motes of dust.

(translation of the *Brahma Net Sutra*)

The concept of enlightenment, in terms of Buddhism, relates to total spiritual knowledge. According to the original Buddha, it is the ultimate wisdom. One of the facets of this understanding is called “Tuka,” the existence of suffering and things that are finite. The second facet of enlightenment is understanding why each of these sufferings come about. To followers of any Buddhist school of thought, each birth, suffering, and death serves a purpose. The third facet of enlightenment is the cessation of suffering, which includes the end of death. Finally, enlightenment includes the knowledge of how to end suffering.

Buddha believed that as humans, we are caught up in the false reality of material things, superficial relationships with objects, and other people. Instead of giving in to cravings for objects, the teachers and students at Nalanda taught that the way to enlightenment was to look past instinctual desires. For these purposes, Buddhists in the Gupta Empire focused on mindfulness, meditation, and minimalism. In terms of the five main abstinences of the religion, enlightenment can be measured by how little you are affected by a life free of stealing, sexual misconduct, lying, intoxication, and killing living creatures.

Education in the Gupta Empire was not just isolated to the Buddhist teachings at Nalanda, however. The Hindu alternative to Nalanda and the Buddhist monasteries of the day were Brahmanical Agraharas, where the subjects of the Vedic texts and subsects like Ayurveda were taught.